

Response 1 –



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Interviewer (Sushanth): Hey, this is Sushanth. I would like to take a survey with you on the topic of misinformation. Do I have your consent?

Respondent: No, I don't have any problem. Please go on with it.

Interviewer (Sushanth): Can I please know your name and age?

Respondent: I am Koushik, 19 years old, currently studying at Mahindra University, second year student.

Interviewer (Sushanth): That's great to know.

Interviewer (Sushanth): So, let's start with the survey. Can you please tell me what social media platforms you use the most often?

Respondent: I currently use Twitter and YouTube just for entertainment purposes.

Interviewer (Sushanth): Oh, that's nice to know.

Interviewer (Sushanth): So, YouTube and Twitter like you mentioned, right? How often or how frequently do you rely on them for news or important information?

Respondent: For me, it's more like social media is where I notice something first. For example, during the recent updates around the Israel and Palestine situation, I first saw short clips and posts on Instagram before I even saw it on any news app. After that, I went and checked view tests to understand what was actually happening. So, I wouldn't say I rely on it fully, but it definitely triggers me to look deeper.

Interviewer (Sushanth): I feel like that's a good way to go about it, to avoid being fed propaganda.

Interviewer (Sushanth): So, going to the next question, have you ever seen information online that you later realized was false? And what was it about?

Respondent: Yeah, there was a video circulating during that same situation or conflict, showing explosions in a city and it was being shared as if it was from that week. Later, it turned out that video was actually from Syria from a few years ago.

Interviewer (Sushanth): Oh, that's quite a unique experience that you have with that.

Interviewer (Sushanth): So, after that, what made you believe that particular piece of information or trust that information initially?

Respondent: I found out it was incorrect when I saw a breakdown thread on Twitter, where someone compared frames from the video with older footage and showed it was reused. Also, Twitter community notes is really helpful for such false news.

Interviewer (Sushanth): Did that information affect your opinion or any decision you made?

Respondent: Yeah, it definitely affected how I felt in that moment. It made the situation seem more immediate and extreme than what was actually confirmed at that moment.

Interviewer (Sushanth): Okay, that's nice to hear. So, after that, have you ever shared something that later turned out to be false? And what happened after that?

Respondent: Yeah, I've shared things like infographics about the current events without checking the original source, assuming they were accurate because they looked well-designed and innovative. So, I guess how it looks is really important for such things.

Interviewer (Sushanth): Yeah, I agree with you on that point about it looking good for people to be clickbaited.

Interviewer (Sushanth): So, after that, do you feel social media shows you certain types of content more often? And why do you think that happens?

Respondent: Yeah, I feel like I'm shown content based on patterns. Like, if I interact with geopolitical posts on once, I start getting more of that type. Even if I didn't actively search for it. This is very irritating and as if it feels like someone intentionally stuffs things I don't really want to do. I really don't want to see them.

Interviewer (Sushanth): That's quite insightful.

Interviewer (Sushanth): So, yeah, on the same topic, do you think posts with more likes, shares and comments are more likely to appear in your feed?

Respondent: Yeah, definitely posts with a lot of shares and comments keep coming back into the feed. Which kind of reinforces them even if they were not fully accurate. All that matters at the point is whether it was able to clickbait people into watching or liking the post.

Interviewer (Sushanth): Okay, so let's end this with knowing what do you think is the biggest problem caused by misinformation online?

Respondent: I think the biggest problem is the outdated or content with a change in context is reused and people don't realize it. So, they react to something that isn't even current. What I mean is that something that a person could be reading today could be from two weeks ago. From when a lot of changes may already have happened.

Interviewer (Sushanth): That was really helpful and that gave me a lot of insight into how you think and how misinformation could be spread online. So, yeah, I also want to let you know that this information will only be used for academic purposes and will not be shared anywhere on the internet. Thanks a lot for your time.

Respondent: Yeah, thank you so much.

Response 2 –



Response2.wav

Interviewer (Sushanth): Hello, this is Sushanth. I would like to take a survey with you regarding the topic of misinformation. Do I have the consent?

Respondent: Yes, you have my consent.

Interviewer (Sushanth): May I please know your name and age, if you are comfortable sharing?

Respondent: I don't prefer sharing my name, but then my age is 19.

Interviewer (Sushanth): That's well and good. It's fine if you don't want to share. So, let's start by knowing what social media platforms you use most often.

Respondent: Most often I use Twitter, Reddit, and if you consider WhatsApp, we are also on WhatsApp.

Interviewer (Sushanth): Yeah, okay, that's nice to know.

Interviewer (Sushanth): And after that, how frequently do you rely on the social media that you mentioned for news or important information?

Respondent: So, for news, I generally rely on Twitter or Reddit sometimes. So, especially for things related to tech or general changes around the world. But I prefer to take it with a grain of salt and tend to check official sources afterwards like the actual government reports and etc.

Interviewer (Sushanth): Okay, so now moving into the actual core of our topic. Have you ever seen information online that you later realized was false and what was it about?

Respondent: So, yes, I do remember one post that WhatsApp was going to start charging users a monthly fee for messaging. It spread pretty widely at one point and the fact that WhatsApp was being used to spread this information about WhatsApp was very funny.

Interviewer (Sushanth): Yeah, I find that quite funny too. Okay, now moving to the next question. What made you believe or trust that information initially?

Respondent: I didn't believe that information initially because it didn't seem very real.

Interviewer (Sushanth): Oh, so you didn't believe it at all. You're very smart. So, did that misinformation affect your opinion or any decision you made or not just that misinformation, any misinformation for that matter of fact?

Respondent: Yes, as I said, I didn't believe it, so it didn't affect anything. But then, yeah, later I checked some misinformation on Meta and then after going through those news reports, I got clarified that it's like fake.

Interviewer (Sushanth): Oh, so you were able to confirm your affirmation that it is fake.

Interviewer (Sushanth): So, now moving to the next question. Have you ever yourself shared something that later turned out to be false? What happened then?

Respondent: It didn't affect any major decision, fortunately, but it did make me briefly think about alternatives like Telegram before realizing it wasn't true. Actually, so I once shared something about changes in YouTube monetization rules without checking the official update. Later, I realized it was only partially true and a lot of important details or information was intentionally made out to form engagement in people.

Interviewer (Sushanth): Oh, yeah, I think I actually remember that moment in the internet history.

Interviewer (Sushanth): So, after that, let's move on to understanding what you feel about social media and how it shows you certain types of content more often.

Respondent: Yes, I think platforms track even small interactions, like how long you pause on something and then push similar content to your feed.

Interviewer (Sushanth): Yeah, I think that's true. Sometimes it feels like I talk about something and then I end up getting the same reels.

Interviewer (Sushanth): So, after that, let's understand what you think about posts with more likes, shares or comments and how they're more likely to appear in your feed. And do you even think that they're more likely to appear in your feed?

Respondent: Yeah, engagement clearly boosts visibility, but I think it creates a loop where most reacted to content becomes the most seen, regardless of the accuracy, like even misinformation coming to my feed.

Interviewer (Sushanth): Yeah, I think I understand what you're saying.

Interviewer (Sushanth): So, yeah, let's end this by knowing what you think is the biggest problem caused by misinformation online.

Respondent: The biggest issue is that repeated misinformation starts to feel familiar and familiarity can sometimes be mistaken for truth. And once that happens, it's very hard to stop spreading the false rumors.

Interviewer (Sushanth): Okay, that was very insightful. I feel like I myself learned a lot from this conversation. So, yeah, I want to end this with telling you that this information will only

be used for academic purposes and will not be shared anywhere on the internet. Thanks a lot for your time.

Response 3 –



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Interviewer (Sushanth): Hello, this is Sushanth. I would like to take a survey with you on the topic of misinformation. Do I have your consent?

Respondent: Yeah.

Interviewer (Sushanth): Let's start by knowing your name and age, if you're comfortable sharing.

Respondent: I am Saathvik. My age is 19.

Interviewer (Sushanth): That's nice to meet you, Saathvik. And let's start by knowing what social media platforms you use most often.

Respondent: I use Insta, YouTube and WhatsApp.

Interviewer (Sushanth): Okay, so how frequently do you rely on Insta, YouTube and WhatsApp for social media news or important information?

Respondent: I think I rely on social media more for everyday updates and most of the free time I spend it on Insta. Moreover, like things related to college, event, city events and sudden announcements.

Interviewer (Sushanth): Really? We have very similar usage.

Interviewer (Sushanth): So have you ever seen information online that you later realized was false? And what is it about?

Respondent: Yeah, I see many fake news and fake messages related to fake messages, like sudden college holidays or exams have been postponed, the exams have been cancelled. These type of messages circulate throughout the college group. And related to the fake information in social media, I recall one situation where it was something related to a movie which I came to know, which was completely fake after watching it.

Interviewer (Sushanth): So what made you believe or trust that information initially?

Respondent: I believed it first because it was followed by multiple people or multiple different people, different groups and moreover, same thing is repeated, mentioned with the same dates, exact dates and stuff, which made me believe completely.

Interviewer (Sushanth): Okay, it feels like you got baited hard by everyone on Instagram. So did that information or actually how did you eventually find out that is incorrect?

Respondent: The movie stuff after watching the movie, I came to realize that this was completely wrong. I also recall my friends trolled me a lot based on that thing. And later someone checked with me that admin office and related to the stuff with exams. Later I confirmed with the admin office that nothing has been changed and everything is going based on the previous dates and stuff.

Interviewer (Sushanth): Okay, so after that, did that misinformation affect your opinion or decision, any decision you made?

Respondent: I didn't affect anything majorly, but few hours I actually planned to schedule my stuff that exams have been postponed.

Interviewer (Sushanth): Okay, that must have been painful.

Interviewer (Sushanth): So after that, have you ever shared something that later turned out to be false? What happened?

Respondent: Yeah, I have forwarded things like, especially when I feel it is urgent and relevant, I share it in groups and the stuff related to movie also, I shared it with my friends and which came to be completely wrong at last. And I also told you they trolled me a lot.

Interviewer (Sushanth): Feels bad man.

Interviewer (Sushanth): So after that, do you feel social media shows you certain types of content more often? And why do you think that happens?

Respondent: Yes, I feel I keep seeing similar type of posts and I feel that obviously the algorithm just thinks I like some stuff and some things and keeps on getting more than more. For example, I love to, I love to code a lot. And if I ever feel or and I ever feel like or repost a coding related reel, I keep getting more and more along with similar coding related posts.

Interviewer (Sushanth): Okay, so on the same topic, do you think that posts with more likes, shares or comments are more likely to appear in a feed?

Respondent: Yeah, posts with more replies or forwards tend to be circulating longer, especially in group chats where same message appears multiple times.

Interviewer (Sushanth): All right, that was very insightful, the whole survey. So let's end with knowing what you think is the biggest problem caused by misinformation online.

Respondent: I think the big problem is that misinformation spreads faster in small circles like colleges, groups where people trust each other more and don't question things as much. So this is the main reason or it causes the problem to be more.

Interviewer (Sushanth): That's a very valid observation. Actually, I think the same.

Interviewer (Sushanth): So yeah, thanks a lot for your time. I'd like to end this by saying that this information will only be used for academic purposes and not be shared anywhere else on the internet. So yeah, thanks a lot for your time, Saathvik.

Respondent: Okay, completely fine. No problem.